



How We Tested

We ran a multitude of tests that stressed each of the three major sub-systems of an MFD, i.e. Printing, Scanning and Copying. We did not conduct performance tests on Fax capabilities, and only evaluated their features. The test computers used were two ACi Emerald Pro laptops with an Intel Pentium 4 2.66 GHz processor, 256 MB of RAM, a 40 GB hard drive and Windows XP with the latest updates as our Operating system. We called for MFDs costing below Rs 1 lakh for the comparison.

Printing

To test the speeds of the printing units, we used three different documents—a plain text document covering 25 per cent of the page, a combination-document of text and some graphics covering 35 per cent of the page and an image file. We logged the time taken by the printer units to print them. To determine the printer output quality, we analysed the test prints taken from the

printer unit during the speed test. We looked for jarring edges in text, and how well images were reproduced in black and white—whether there was any banding across the image, etc. We also looked at the smallest possible font that the printer unit could print.

Scanning

To test scanning speeds, we used an A4 photograph that was scanned at 600 dpi with 24-bit colour. Before any scans, we accounted for the time taken for a scanner unit to warm up, by taking five previews before scanning anything. We logged the time taken to scan the document and display the output in Photoshop.

Testing the scanning quality involved an assortment of tests, the two most important being:-

Image quality test using IT8 card:

Professionals all over the world use IT8 cards to gauge the colour purity of a scanned image. This card was scanned at

300 dpi, and the colour reproduction in both light and dark spectrums was noted. **Image Quality test using a resolution chart:** This test determines which device is better at picking up minute details. A resolution chart with lines was scanned at a resolution of 300 dpi; we then used the magic wand feature in Photoshop to analyse the scanned blocks. Marks were awarded to MFDs that could differentiate the maximum number of lines.

Copying

In order to test copying speeds, we used a text document consisting of varying font sizes. We placed the test printout on the scanner, and noted the copies per minute.

Features

We noted all the features that a device offered in terms of usability in everyday life. Special features such as poster-printing, duplexing, auto-resize, etc, were also assigned the appropriate importance.

great-looking machine. HP uses its traditional navy blue body with grey panels, colourful buttons and throw in a dash of style with some flashy lights. The major difference between HP and Brother is that the former's models are more compact. Canon uses sky-blue with milky-white panels and ends up looking the best of the lot. Samsung and Xerox have the smallest footprint. Canon iC D680 is a heavyweight at 22 kg, while HP's LJ3030 and LJ3020 are the lightest at 12 kg. All models in this category have an LCD display. Brother scores with a great four-line backlit LCD. The rest have a single-line LCD that displays limited information.

Printing

Barring a few differences in specifications, all the devices are evenly matched in terms of features. The printer engines support a maximum of 600 dpi—more than enough for a typical business scenario. All have a 250-sheet capacity—except HP's LJ3020 and 3030, which have a capacity of 150 sheets. All HP models and Samsung 4216F support additional paper trays—the rest lack this flexibility. The output paper trays on HP's 3030 and 3020 are a bit flimsy. Coming to one of the most important

Among the workgroup MFDs, the elegant Canon models are ahead in the race for good looks.

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